

Compsognathus

COMP-sog-NAITH-us



- **When** 150 million years ago (Late Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** Germany, France
- **Habitat** Scrubland and marshes
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Lizards, small mammals, baby dinosaurs

With its large eyes, clawed hands, and sharp, curved teeth, *Compsognathus* was a typical carnivorous dinosaur, but it was only the size of a chicken. Like a bird, it had hollow bones that kept its body light. Running swiftly on the tips of its toes, this lightweight predator could outpace fast-moving prey such as lizards, before pouncing on its victim. Its long tail was more than half of its total body length and was used for balance, helping it make sharp turns as it dashed about. Scientists think fuzzy feathers covered most of its body, especially its back.



Compsognathus fossil

▼ HUNTER OR SCAVENGER?

Like any carnivore, Compsognathus sometimes came across dead animals and would have scavenged for scraps of meat. But its agile build and sharp little teeth show it was more of a hunter than a scavenger, built to capture nervous little animals before they scampered under rocks or disappeared into the undergrowth.

Sinosauropteryx

SIGH-no-sore-OP-ter-ix



- **When** 130–125 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** China
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Small animals

In 1996 the first feathered dinosaur, *Sinosauropteryx*, was discovered in the Liaoning Quarry, China. The fossil bore clear marks of simple, fluffy feathers covering the back and sides of the body. Such feathers probably served to keep the animal warm by trapping a layer of air next to the skin.



Sinosauropteryx also had the longest tail, relative to its body size, of any flesh-eating dinosaur.

